

PILLARS OF MEMORY The exhibition on display at the Archivio di Stato in Venice

who quietly care for them. "The caretakers of these archives, the guardians of our past for the future, are rarely seen and almost never celebrated. The exhibition is also a tribute to them." Anastasio believes this challenges conventional ideas of preservation. "Traditional archives aspire to permanence," he says. "Dayanita's archive accepts incompleteness...as intrinsic qualities." The exhibition's domestic-scale wooden structures encourage visitors to wander and create their own connections between images.

After Venice, ARCHIVIO will travel to the Museo Nazionale Etrusco di Villa Giulia in Rome, the MAO (Museo d'Arte Orientale) in Turin and the Italian embassy cultural centre in New Delhi. ARCHIVIO proposes a different understanding of photography itself, one built on memory, movement and human connection. "When I speak of photography as friendship," Singh reflects, "the obvious question is: photography or friendship? I would always choose friendship." ■

—Nikhil Sardana

ARCHIVIO is on view in Venice till **Jul. 31**

ART ▼

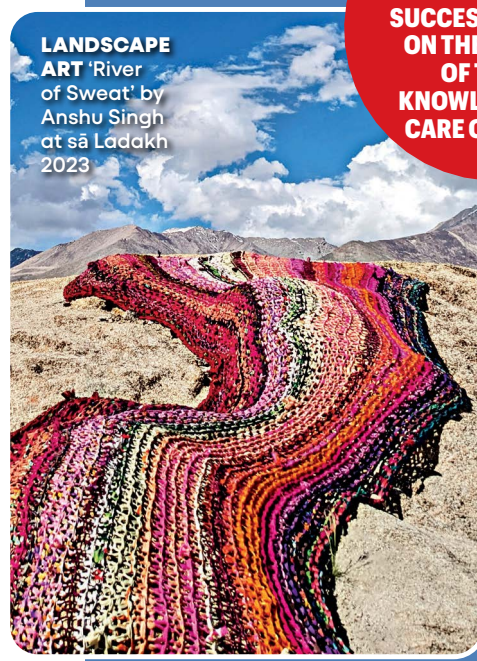
Aiming Higher

The first edition of the **SĀ LADAKH BIENNALE** is set to unfold across eight sites, all the way from Leh to Kargil

No, unlike many curators, Raki Nikahetiya didn't descend with a concept to impose and move pieces to fit his vision. As co-founder of sā Ladakh Biennale, the region's first art biennale, he did the opposite. He listened. For someone born in Sri Lanka, raised in Austria, and now working across multiple cities, he could easily have brought a ready-made 'mountain template' to the icy heights. But



CO-FOUNDER RAKI NIKAHETIYA FEELS THE BIENNALE'S SUCCESS DEPENDS ON THE GROWTH OF TRUST, KNOWLEDGE AND CARE OVER TIME



LANDSCAPE ART 'River of Sweat' by Anshu Singh at sā Ladakh 2023

Ladakh touched him first. "This place completely changed the rhythm at which I think," he says.

Even as the first edition, 'Signals from Another Star', curated by artist Vishal K. Dar, will take place from August 1–10, Nikahetiya is quick to point out that he and his co-founders, Sagardeep Singh and Tenzing Jamyang, never set out to build a biennale. "It was curiosity that brought us here, not a drive to establish something," he stresses.

While sā, named for the Ladakhi word for 'soil', was held in 2023 and 2024 as an annual "regenerative land art exhibition and experience" in Leh, 2026 marks the inaugural edition of the biennale format, which will take place across eight sites—Leh, Likir, Basgo, Nurla, Lamayuru, Henasku, Mulbekh and Kargil—along the 230-km Leh–Kargil corridor. Participating artists include Chemat Dorjey, Tom Müller, Tundup Dorjay, Hylozoic/Desires, Avantika Bawa, and Zahara Batool.

Before the first edition of sā was held in 2023, for several years, the team focused only on one thing—listening to local communities, artists, researchers, in India and abroad. Raki's own life spent across cultures made him wary of art projects wrapped in preset answers. Ladakh revealed to him that memory doesn't just reside in people but is also held in glaciers, monasteries and oral histories.

Raki insists that success to him is not measured only by attendance or coverage, but whether trust, knowledge and care continue to grow over time. Asked where he sees sā in 10 years, he says it is what it leaves behind. A Youth Advisory Board is already being set up so the institution can keep renewing itself. "I do not think in terms of legacy, but continuity." ■

—Sukant Deepak

The biennale is on from Aug. 1-10